

had issued guidelines facilitating collaborations between Indian universities and FEIs in the field of technical education and research.

Since then, only two universities from the UK and one from the US have registered their partnerships with home-grown institutions. But that is the official number. The All-India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) claims that as many as 104 FEIs are actually collaborating with our universities and affiliated colleges but without its approval. The unregistered collaborations are being treated as illegal by the HRD Ministry. "This sector has a few problems but all stakeholders should get together and discuss the issues," says Supriya Sule, NCP leader and member of the parliamentary standing committee on HRD. The Congress has found support from both NCP and BJP on the proposed legislation.

UPA constituents, barring the Left, have extended help to the Congress. So has the Opposition NDA. Yet the Congress leadership might not be able to see through the policy change. The lack of consensus on reforms in higher education plagues the Planning Commission too—Left-leaning mem-

THE FOREIGN ARGUMENT

Foreign universities rob India of \$4 bn (Rs 16,220 cr) yearly. About 1,60,000 students leave for overseas education annually.

India could earn \$500 m (Rs 2,027 cr) every year from 50,000 foreign students.

Only 3 foreign varsities, which have Indian tie-ups, are registered with the Government. 104 FEIs operate sans AICTE approval.

Over 10 per cent students (1.05 crore) in 17-23 age group are enrolled in higher education institutes in India.

Government spending on higher education is 0.7 per cent of the GDP. Overall, 3.79 per cent of the GDP is spent on education.

bers are said to be wary of FEIs entering India. Disharmony led to the cancellation of a full meeting of the commission scheduled for August 6—it was to discuss, among other matters, allocation of funds to education under the 11th Plan. The Government had promised to spend 6 per cent of GDP on education in the plan period but that may stay unfulfilled. At present, only 0.7 per cent of the GDP is spent on higher education and 3.79 per cent on education overall.

The Government's pro-reforms lobby, which includes Planning Commission Deputy Chairman Montek Singh Ahluwalia, seems to be spinning this very logic the other way. According to Government estimates, at least Rs 48,000 crore would be needed to build 30 Central universities in 16 states over five years. UPA reformists feel that while higher public spending on education is necessary, the Government is constrained in its ability to spend more. Besides, the Commerce Ministry has estimated that 1,60,000 Indian students leave the country every year for foreign university/college education. Not only does the trend mean greater brain drain but it also leads to an annual outgo of \$4 billion or Rs 16,220 crore.

In its report to the prime minister last November, the National Knowledge Commission (NKC) had recommended that FEIs be allowed to come to India, as it would help stem the flight of talent to foreign shores and curtail the outgo substantially. "We must formulate appropriate policies for the entry of foreign institutions into India and the promotion of Indian institutions abroad," says NKC Chairman Sam Pitroda. According to NKC, at least 1,500 new universities would be needed to increase the gross enrolment rate from 10 per cent to 15 per cent by 2015. Unfortunately, only 1.05 crore of India's youth in the age group of 17 to 23 are enrolled in higher education institutes. At the time of Independence, there were 20 universities and 500 colleges in India. Much has changed in 60 years. There are 369 universities and 18,064 colleges now. Will foreign universities and affiliated colleges fulfil India's demand? There are more assumptions than answers. ■



SIPRA DASS

SAM PITRODA, HEAD, KNOWLEDGE PANEL

Submitted a report on reforms in higher education to the PM last November. Says it is necessary to formulate appropriate policies for the entry of foreign institutions in India and the promotion of Indian institutions abroad. The PM is learnt to have assured Pitroda that his report would be implemented.

YASRAT NEGI

SUKDEO THORAT, CHAIRMAN, UGC

Fearing the PM's endorsement of the Knowledge Commission report, presented a strategy paper to the HRD Ministry in June. Promised more funds for existing colleges and universities to enable them enhance their intake. Says UGC will focus on 350 educationally-backward districts.